SANKARA, L'ÉTERNEL VEILLEUR

A monumental Corten steel sculpture by the Burkinabè artist designer Hamed Ouattara, raised at the Parco Thomas Sankara in Rome, the only public space in Europe given over entirely to the memory of Comrade President Thomas Sankara.

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SANKARA, L'ÉTERNEL VEILLEUR, Hamed Ouattara, 2026, Corten steel.
Parco Thomas Sankara, Via Ugo della Seta, III Municipio, Rome, Italy.
Collection of the Burkinabè State, Ministry of Communication, Culture, Arts and Tourism (MCCAT).

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Specification

Title	*SANKARA, L'ÉTERNEL VEILLEUR*
Author	Hamed Ouattara, 2026
Nature	Monumental sculpture, hollow rectangular prism
Material	Corten steel, 6 mm thick
Dimensions	200 × 70 × 70 cm, base excluded
Texture	Hemispherical bosses, 139 mm across, standing 20 to 25 mm proud
Number of bosses	48 per textured face, 28 per portrait face, 152 in all
Estimated weight	About 370 kg
Finish	Bare Corten, left to oxidise freely over time
Base	Stepped reinforced concrete, cast on site
Unveiling	**Saturday 24 October 2026**
Siting	Parco Thomas Sankara, Via Ugo della Seta, III Municipio, Rome, Italy
Design	Studio Hamed Ouattara, Ouagadougou, Burkina Faso
Fabrication	Italy, Bologna area

The technique

Two opposite faces carry the portrait of Comrade President Thomas Sankara, obtained by cutting clean through the plate in negative space: it is the voids opened in the steel that make the face, the starred beret and the gaze. Through those openings the visitor sees the half-darkness inside the monument. The portrait therefore has no colour of its own: it is made of shadow, and it changes with the hour and with where the viewer stands.

The dark areas of the portrait are voids straight through the steel, the light areas are the steel left in place: it is the contrast between metal and daylight that builds the figure, with the sharpness of a great stencil. The side bands framing the face are left smooth.

The two other faces carry no cut at all. They are covered with hemispherical bosses formed in the thickness of the plate itself. The name block ISIDORE NOEL THOMAS SANKARA 1949 - 1987 and the author's signature, 340 by 40 mm at the foot of the face, are cut on the same principle.

Reading the numbers

Nothing in the weave of the monument is left to chance. The numbers it carries come out of the artist's research, and were settled before the first line was drawn: the grid of the work counts those who fell with him, and the day it all began.

- **12 rows on every face** — the twelve **companions** who fell with him on 15 October 1987.
- **4 columns of bosses** — **4 August 1983**, the opening of the Democratic and Popular Revolution. The sculpture itself has four faces.
- **2 faces carrying the portrait** — the two **directions**, north and south, for the one arriving as much as for the one leaving.

The weave is the same on all four faces: forty-eight places, twelve rows of four. On the two faces that carry the portrait, twenty of those places are given back to the void — sixteen for the face, four for the name block. Where the metal has not been struck, that is him.

Exact count: 48 bosses per textured face — 4 columns × 12 rows —, 28 per portrait face — four in the top row, twenty-four in the lower part —, **152 in all**.

“These numbers come out of my research, and I settled them before I drew. A memorial sculpture that counted nothing would be mere ornament: this one had to carry a date and names, and the form was built around them.” — Hamed Ouattara, statement of intent, Ouagadougou, 2026.

The story of the project

The Parco Thomas Sankara in Rome was carried by Comrade Madi Sakandé, of the Burkinabè diaspora in Italy. He is the donor of the work, to the benefit of the Burkinabè State. He asked Hamed Ouattara for a work, and not a statue.

The figurative statue was set aside for three reasons. The place is an urban park people walk through, not a dedicated memorial site: a work legible from every angle belongs there better. Corten steel withstands the European climate without maintenance. Finally, the plastic language

used — salvaged metal, pressed bosses, volumes drawn from Sudano-Sahelian earthen architecture — is the one developed over more than twenty years in Ouagadougou: it makes this monument a Burkinabè work in full, and not a commission carried out in a borrowed style.

Hamed Ouattara designed the work in full, from the sculptural decision through to the vector files for cutting. The steel plates were worked in Italy by workshops equipped for laser cutting and for pressing the bosses. **The assembly, the welding and the finishing were done by the artist in person**, in Bologna, before transport and installation in Rome.

A monument complementary to the national Memorial

SANKARA, L'ÉTERNEL VEILLEUR is complementary to, and distinct from, the Thomas Sankara Memorial rising in Burkina Faso. It is neither its replica nor its extension, and it replaces it in nothing. The hearth of that memory remains in Ouagadougou. This monument is a Burkinabè artistic contribution carried abroad, which belongs to the national movement for the restoration of the memory of Comrade President Thomas Sankara, under the aegis of the Ministry of Communication, Culture, Arts and Tourism (Ministère de la Communication, de la Culture, des Arts et du Tourisme).

The author

Hamed Ouattara, whose civil name is OUATTARA Mohamed Sékou, is a Burkinabè multidisciplinary artist designer, a graduate of the École nationale supérieure de création industrielle in Paris. In 2002 he founded the Studio Hamed Ouattara in Ouagadougou, on the Route du SIAO, a workshop organised as a guild with some fifteen craftsmen.

His practice turns salvaged industrial metal into sculptural pieces that carry African memory and identity, in a vocabulary drawn from Sudano-Sahelian earthen architecture.

His works are in the permanent collections of the Victoria and Albert Museum in London, the Centre Pompidou in Paris, the Vitra Design Museum, the Brooklyn Museum and the Denver Art Museum. He is represented exclusively by the Friedman Benda Gallery in New York, has been a Chevalier de l'Ordre du mérite des Arts since 2014, won the Africa Design Award in the same year, and is president of the Association Art Contemporain du Burkina Faso.

Contact and images

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